Poems from Guantanamo Bay

or Guilty until Proven Innocent

Edited By Mark Falkoff

Peace they say.
Peace of mind?
Peace of earth?
Peace of what kind?
I see them talking arguing, fighting –
What kind of peace are they looking for?
Why do they kill? What are they planning?
Is it just talk? Why do they argue?
Is it so simple to kill? Is this their plan?
Yes, of course!
They talk, they argue, they kill –
They fight for peace.

INTRODUCTION

One of the most laudable tenets of American law is the assurance that anyone accused of a crime is "innocent until proven guilty." However, this fundamental legal right seems to have taken a reverse path in the post 9/11 world, especially when it comes to Muslims. These racially targeted individuals are more often "guilty until proven innocent," and this is a rather disturbing vein in the realm of American democracy and international human rights. Since 2002, at least 775 men have been held in the U.S. detention center at Guantanamo Bay, Cuba. According to Department of

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Defense data, fewer than half of them are accused of committing any hostile act against the United States or its allies. In hundreds of cases, even the circumstances of their initial detainment are questionable. Despite President Obama's promise two years ago to shut down the Guantánamo Bay detention center, as of August 2011 it remains open. This collection gives voice to the men held at Guantanamo. If, in the words of Audre Lorde, poetry "forms the quality of light within which we predicate our hopes and dreams toward survival and change," these verses—some originally written in toothpaste, others scratched onto foam drinking cups with pebbles and furtively handed to attorneys—are the most basic form of the art.

Today I offer you art in the form of Poems from Guantanamo Bay: The Detainees Speak. The collection includes They Fight for Peace by Shaker Abdurraheem Aamer, a British citizen; Humiliated In The Shackles by Sami al Hajj, a Sudanese journalist; Terrorist 2003 by Martin Mubanga, an athletic kick-boxer and First Poem of My Life by Mohammed El-Gharani, a 14-year old detainee.

Poems are interspersed and are color-coded to assist in the dramatic portrayal of each "character"

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- **They Fight for Peace by Shaker Abdurraheem Aamer**
- **Humiliated In The Shackles by Sami al Hajj**
- **Terrorist 2003 by Martin Mubanga**
- **First Poem of My Life by Mohammed El-Gharani**

Hustle cautiously in the land of those who speak no
Arabic!
Even if they gave you oaths bound by oaths.
Their aim is to worship petty cash
And for it they break all vows.
I came to their land to pursue an education,
And saw such malice among them.
They surrounded the mosque, weapons drawn,
As if they were in a field of` war.
They said to us, "Come out peacefully,
And don't utter a single word."
Into a transport truck they lifted us,
And in shackles of injustice they bound us.

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For sixteen hours we walked;
For the entire time we remained in shackles.

Humiliated in the Shackels . . .

When I heard pigeons cooing in the trees,
Hot tears covered my face.
When the lark chirped, my thoughts composed
A message for my son.
Mohammad, I am afflicted.
In my despair, I have no one but Allah for comfort.
The oppressors are playing with me,
As they move freely around the world.
They ask me to spy on my countrymen,
Claiming it would be a good deed.
They offer me money and land,
And freedom to go where I please.
Their temptations seize
My attention like lightning in the sky.
But their gift is an empty snake,
Carrying hypocrisy in its mouth like venom,

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America sucks, America chills,
While d' blood of d' Musllims is forever getting spilled,
In d' streets of Nablus, in d' streets of Jenin,
Yeahhhhhh! You know what I mean.

American Gangstas, American lies
In downtown LA, they was burning rubber tyres.
After Rodney King they woz burning 'nough fires.
Yeahhhhhh! Them mother sumthing liars.

American justice, American pigs,
American soldiers, American wigs.
Yes I'm feeling angry, yes I'm feeling pissed,
An' it's about time that the JIF got dissed.

JIF – Joint Interrogation Facility at Guantanamo

Now them ask me, what will ya do if ya leave the prison?
Will ya be able to slip back into d' system?
What ya gonna do with ya new-found fame?
An' will ya ever, ever go jihad again?

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All of us wanted to move our bowels
But they insisted on denying us.

The soldier struck with his boot;
He said we were all equally subjects.

In the prison's darkness they spread us out
In the cold's bitterness we sat.....

When the red-faced infidels came to spend their money,
Never had I seen such tribulation.

In a warplane they brought us up,
And after a half hour, brought us down.

We saw such insults from them;
Not even the book of God was protected.

Along with their malice, they were foolish.
Tribulations, then hitting and imbecility.

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For they are a people without reasonable minds,
Due to their supply of alcoholic drinks.

They have monuments to liberty
And freedom of opinion, which is well and good.
But I explained to them that
Architecture is not justice.
America, you ride on the backs of orphans,
And terrorize them daily.
Bush, beware.
The world recognizes an arrogant liar.
To Allah I direct my grievance and my tears.
I am homesick and oppressed.

An' them er says to me, if ya's walking down d' street,
Sees a fine girl will ya sweep her off her feet?
Or leave her standing thinking that she sweet,
For the next mans to come and reap?

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An' them er says to me, no you's back from d' core,
You're a terrorist, a big-time hardcore.
But my friends them know the score,
Cause back in d' day me use to g'waan juss like a whore.
Now me a Muslim, so me whan . . . . . shut that door.

But the government's them, them a feeling sore!
Cause like a page in a book you know me done a tore
A hole in them heart, them exposing hypocrisy,
For all the world them to clearly come 'n see.

Now them ask me, will ya come work for us?
Had to hold my breath so they would not hear me cuss,
Dumb mother sumthings, I'd rather suck pus,
Than work for the mans that Allah did a cuss.

Mohammad, do not forget me.
Support the cause of your father, a God-fearing man.
I was humiliated in the shackles.
How can I now compose verses? How can I now write?

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After the shackles and the nights and the suffering and
the tears,
How can I write poetry?
My soul is like a roiling sea, stirred by anguish,
Violent with passion.
I am a captive, but the crimes are my captors'.
I am overwhelmed with apprehension.
Lord, unite me with my son Mohammad.
Lord, grant success to the righteous.

The "Red Cross" arrived, in our state of need
On the condition that we raise the card with a cross.

"If you want dignity and protection,
Then raise the cross for protection."

All of us threw the card away,
Intent that our spirits be redeemed.

They carried us, afterwards, to Cuba,
Because it is an afflicted isle.

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Out of spite, they showed such impudence.
Their war is against Islam and justice.

An' them a says to me, we can make your life sweet,
Give you all the things you ever wanted to eat.
All you got to do is practice deceit,
An' everything a go be really neat.

"Sauf ofaker fi haza. Let me think about about it."
Qurrratu Qur'an. There was no need to doubt it,
Did you think for a second I really did doubt it?
There wasn't even need for me to go shout it.

They're scum, they're criminals, on their way to hell,
And not for all of the dunya would I join them as well!

Now me's coming with these lyrics from Guantanamo B,
In my prison cell down by the sea,
For hard-core detainees like you an' me.
Terrorist 2003,
So called. Yeah, that's me!

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Qurrratu Qur'an – Arabic for I read the Qur'an
dunya – Arabic for wordly, material things as opposed to spiritual matters

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